The Chinese leadership, on the other hand, was the 'later' school. It concluded that China was not ready to deal with the border problem as it was still trying to bring Tibet under control. It recognized among other things that Tibet was highly dependent on 'vital commodities' from India, which was the largest destination for some key Tibetan exports. Beijing was annoyed by what it saw as Indian attempts to manipulate Tibet's economic vulnerability but concluded that, as it moved to integrate the province, a diplomatic row with Delhi was better avoided.[12] China would therefore only 'raise the issue to recover these regions' after it was 'well prepared'.[13] The Chinese central government also had other reasons for refusing to raise the matter with India. Nehru was being helpful at the time in the repatriation of Chinese prisoners in the Korean war, in paving the way for China's participation in the Bandung Afro-Asian Conference of 1955, and in helping set up informal diplomatic talks between China and the US.[14]

Contradictions and inconsistencies

By 1954, the two countries were overcoming their hesitations in raising the border issue but were saying and doing contradictory and inconsistent things, at least in the other side's view. At their first meeting in June 1954, Nehru and Zhou discussed world affairs but apparently did not deal with their territorial concerns. Yet, after the meeting, the Indian leader was worried enough to order India to change its maps to show Aksai Chin and what was then NEFA as part of India. As soon as the maps were published, they would have been available to China. Beijing could very well have seen Delhi's actions as duplicitous: maintaining a silence over the border during the summit and moving immediately thereafter to revise its maps. Chinese behaviour also seemed contradictory. Zhou had failed to mention the border in his meeting with Nehru, but just days later, on 17 July 1954, China protested the presence of Indian troops in Barahoti (in present-day Uttarakhand) – the first signs that Beijing had a clear, firm view of its boundaries and would not be quiescent.